Reading Practices and the Printed Page

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It is crucial to note that annotation was taught. The assumption that marginalia are spontaneous expressions of individual response has obscured the degree to which readers were trained to produce them. Printed textbooks of the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries routinely included model notes, and schoolmasters were instructed to require imitation before invention.

This pedagogy produced a recognizable grammar of marks. A vertical line in the margin signaled a passage worth returning to; a bracket gathered a sequence of sentences into a single unit of argument; a brief word, often no more than "nota" or "quaere," recorded a judgment without specifying its grounds. The grammar was conventional, but its application was not.

Consequently, the study of annotation must distinguish between the mark and its occasion. The same symbol may register assent in one copy and dissent in another, and without external evidence the historian cannot always tell which. Consequently, claims about the emotional or intellectual life of past readers should be advanced with unusual caution.

Gender complicates the picture further. Women readers certainly annotated, but their books survive less often, and when they do survive they are less likely to be catalogued as evidence of scholarship. The archive has tended to classify women's marks as personal and men's as intellectual, a distinction that reflects the assumptions of cataloguers more than the practices of readers.

Furthermore, the material record is uneven across genres. Devotional works, household manuals, and schoolbooks are heavily marked; folio histories and law books are not. Furthermore, the marks cluster in the places where a book was designed to be used: indexes, tables, and the opening pages of chapters.

A history of reading built from these traces must therefore be a history of infrastructure as much

as of intention. What readers could write, where they could write it, and who was permitted to keep the result are questions that precede any interpretation of the notes themselves.

The classroom is the likeliest origin of most of the marks that survive. A schoolboy trained to bracket the topic sentence and to underline the conclusion carried that habit into every book he later owned. The result is a corpus that looks spontaneous but is in fact the residue of instruction, repeated until it became invisible.

This has consequences for how we describe readerly agency. To say that a reader "responded" to a text is to borrow a vocabulary of freedom that the evidence does not always support. Often the reader was executing a lesson, and the interest of the note lies precisely in the gap between the lesson and the sentence it was applied to.